On the night of 25 August, just as the hostages were preparing to retire for the night, they received the ominous order that they were immediately to be moved northwards into the Hindu Kush. By the light of the moon they were made to load their few remaining goods on to the ponies and camels that had been sent for them by Akbar Khan. The women were told for the first time to wear full-length Afghan burkhas. Mackenzie, who had gone down with a severe fever and believed he was dying, was placed in a wicker basket called a *kajawah* slung from the side of a camel.[63] Off they set, past the outskirts of Kabul and the walls of Babur's Tomb, and out on to the Kohistan road. Their initial destination, they learned, was to be Akbar Khan's northernmost fortress which commanded the old Buddhist valley of Bamiyan, famous for its monumental Buddhas.[64]

The head of their escort of 400 irregular horse was a Qizilbash cavalry officer named Saleh Mohammad Khan. He had been in the service of Shah Shuja until he went over to Dost Mohammad on the latter's return from Bukhara in 1840. George Lawrence and Hugh Johnson both knew him a little from this time, while Eldred Pottinger discovered that ten of the guards were his former troopers who had assisted him during the siege of Herat in 1838. There were even two of Mackenzie's jezailchis who had fought by his side during the cantonment siege.[65] Pottinger, Lawrence, Johnson and Mackenzie all quickly realised the opportunity and opened communications to see if any of their guards would be receptive to bribery. At first they all demurred. But as the party headed north on the steep and precipitous caravan route over the wild mountains of Kulu and hence through the high-altitude faultlines of the Hazara country, and as reports began coming in of the crushing victories of Pollock and Nott, the attitude of the guards began to change.

It was Johnson who first made some progress. 'Salih Mahomed is a good humoured, jolly fellow,' he wrote in his journal on 25 August,

> and without any prejudices against us kafirs. He is a soldier of fortune who cares little whom he seizes, has been to Bokhara, and was at the taking of Coucem a few months ago. I rode with him the whole march and was very much amused by his traveller's tales. He is the greatest hero in his own estimation. There is no end to his feats of valour to which I am a ready listener and for two reasons. First that I am amused, secondly that he is flattered by my being a good listener, by which I hope to turn him to good account.